

Country Background

Somalia is located in the Horn of Africa. It borders Djibouti to the northwest, Ethiopia to the west, Kenya to the southwest, the Gulf of Aden to the north, and the Indian Ocean to the east. The country has one of Africa's longest coastlines.

The population is predominantly Somali-speaking and Muslim. Somali communities are connected through family, clan, religious, pastoral, trading, and regional networks. Somalia is governed through a federal system consisting of the Federal Government of Somalia and Federal Member States.

Somalia has significant agricultural, livestock, fishing, and maritime resources. However, poverty, insecurity, limited infrastructure, weak public institutions, unemployment, drought, floods, and restricted access to education and healthcare continue to affect millions of people.

Independence and the First Republic

Somalia became independent on 1 July 1960 after the former British Somaliland and Italian Somaliland territories united. The country initially operated as a parliamentary republic.

In October 1969, Major General Mohamed Siad Barre seized power through a military coup. His government introduced a centralized socialist system and expanded state control over political, economic, and social institutions.

During the 1970s and 1980s, Somalia experienced political repression, armed opposition, economic difficulties, and tensions between the central government and different regions and communities.

Collapse of the Government in 1991

President Siad Barre was overthrown in January 1991. The collapse of the central government created a power vacuum. Rival armed factions competed for control of Mogadishu, regional territories, ports, roads, airports, markets, and natural resources.

The breakdown of national institutions severely affected the police, courts, healthcare system, education system, public administration, and economy. Many communities experienced killings, looting, sexual violence, forced displacement, destruction of property, and loss of livelihoods.

The conflict also contributed to famine and widespread humanitarian suffering. Hundreds of thousands of Somalis fled to Kenya, Ethiopia, Djibouti, Yemen, and other countries. Millions remained displaced within Somalia.

International Humanitarian and Military Intervention

During the early 1990s, the international community organized humanitarian operations to deliver food and protect aid supplies. The United Nations Operation in Somalia and the United States-led Unified Task Force attempted to restore security and support humanitarian assistance.

The intervention faced strong resistance from armed factions. The 1993 Battle of Mogadishu resulted in significant casualties and became one of the most widely known episodes of the international intervention. United States forces withdrew in 1994, and the United Nations completed its withdrawal in 1995.

Somalia continued to experience political fragmentation and armed conflict after the departure of international forces.

Transitional Governments and Federalism

The Transitional Federal Government was established in 2004 as part of an effort to rebuild a national Somali state. In 2012, Somalia adopted a provisional constitution and established a new Federal Government.

Federal Member States were subsequently formed, including Puntland, Jubaland, South West State, Galmudug, and Hirshabelle. Somaliland operates as a self-declared independent administration in the northwest, although it is internationally recognized as part of Somalia.

Political disagreements between the Federal Government and Federal Member States have continued to affect elections, security arrangements, resource sharing, constitutional reform, and the distribution of political authority.

Rise of the Islamic Courts Union and Al-Shabaab

In the mid-2000s, the Islamic Courts Union gained control over parts of Mogadishu and southern Somalia. It provided courts, security, and local administration in areas where state institutions were weak.

Ethiopian forces entered Somalia in December 2006 with international support and removed the Islamic Courts Union from power. Al-Shabaab developed from networks associated with the Islamic Courts Union and became a powerful armed Islamist organization.

Al-Shabaab has conducted attacks against government institutions, military bases, hotels, restaurants, markets, schools, airports, public gatherings, humanitarian personnel, and civilians. The group has also imposed illegal taxation, operated checkpoints, recruited and abducted people, restricted movement, and enforced its rules through intimidation and violence.

Al-Shabaab remains particularly influential in parts of southern and central Somalia, although the extent of its control changes over time.

Main Drivers of Conflict

Somalia's conflict is caused by several connected political, social, economic, and environmental factors. These include competition for political power, disputes between federal and regional authorities, clan and sub-clan tensions, control of land and trade routes, competition over water and grazing areas, extremist violence, weak justice institutions, poverty, unemployment, and lack of public services.

Climate-related shocks intensify these problems. Drought destroys livestock and crops, while flooding damages homes, roads, farms, schools, and health facilities. The loss of livelihoods can increase displacement, competition over resources, child labour, early marriage, and recruitment by armed groups.

The conflict should not be described as a conflict between all Somali clans or as a purely religious war. It includes political struggles, armed extremism, local disputes, resource competition, criminality, institutional weakness, and climate-related pressures.

Impact on Civilians

Civilians have suffered the greatest consequences of the conflict. Families have lost homes, farms, livestock, businesses, and relatives. Many communities have experienced interrupted education, inadequate healthcare, food shortages, poor sanitation, and limited access to clean water.

People living in rural areas may face road insecurity, checkpoints, explosive devices, drought, flooding, and limited access to hospitals. People in urban areas may face terrorist attacks, forced evictions, overcrowded settlements, unemployment, high food prices, and inadequate public services.

Women and girls face increased risks of rape, sexual exploitation, forced marriage, domestic violence, trafficking, and abuse. Children face recruitment, abduction, family separation, malnutrition, interruption of education, and exposure to violence.

Displacement

Somalia has one of the world's longest-running internal displacement crises. People are displaced by armed conflict, clan violence, drought, floods, eviction, loss of livestock, and destruction of livelihoods.

According to UNHCR information published in July 2026, Somalia had approximately 3.3 million internally displaced people as of 30 June 2026. During the same period, Somalia was hosting approximately 32,966 refugees and asylum-seekers. Women and children represented approximately 70 percent of the refugee and asylum-seeker population.

Displaced people often live in informal settlements where they may lack secure shelter, clean water, sanitation, healthcare, education, legal documentation, and protection from violence. Some also face eviction from land occupied by displacement settlements.

Humanitarian Situation in 2026

The Somalia Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan for 2026 estimated that approximately 4.8 million people required humanitarian assistance. The main causes included conflict, drought, flooding, food insecurity, disease outbreaks, displacement, malnutrition, and economic hardship.

Humanitarian needs are not distributed equally. Southern and central regions affected by conflict often face restricted access to assistance. Rural communities affected by drought may lose livestock and move toward urban centres. Displaced families may require food, shelter, protection, healthcare, water, sanitation, and education simultaneously.

Humanitarian conditions can change rapidly after an armed attack, drought, flood, disease outbreak, failed rainy season, or major population movement. Figures should therefore always be connected to the date and organization that reported them.

Major Humanitarian Emergencies

Drought

Drought reduces water supplies, kills livestock, damages crops, increases food prices, and forces rural families to move. Past droughts have caused large-scale displacement and increased severe malnutrition among children.

Flooding

Floods can destroy homes, farms, roads, bridges, latrines, water points, schools, and health centres. Floodwaters can also increase the spread of cholera, acute watery diarrhoea, malaria, and other diseases.

Hunger and Malnutrition

Food insecurity is caused by conflict, drought, flooding, displacement, loss of income, livestock deaths, high food prices, and restricted humanitarian access. Children under five, pregnant women, breastfeeding mothers, displaced households, and families without stable income face the highest risks.

Disease Outbreaks

Somalia faces recurring outbreaks of cholera, acute watery diarrhoea, measles, malaria, respiratory infections, and other diseases. Outbreaks are more dangerous in

overcrowded settlements where people lack clean water, sanitation, vaccination, and medical care.

Explosive Devices

Landmines, improvised explosive devices, unexploded ordnance, and other remnants of war threaten civilians, especially children, farmers, pastoralists, aid workers, and people travelling on rural roads. People should never touch, move, or approach suspicious objects.